

India's Living Tribal Heritage

Eight communities. Eight Landscapes. One living heritage.

Sonali Rajput

September 22, 2026



India's Tribal Diversity

India is home to hundreds of tribal communities, each connected to distinct landscapes, histories and cultural traditions. This story explores eight communities from across the country and the places that shape their way of life.



Bhotia: Life in the High Himalayas

The Bhotia communities live across the Himalayan region, where high mountains, valleys and seasonal movement have shaped traditional livelihoods and cultural practices.





Apatani: Culture in the Eastern Himalayas

In the Ziro Valley of Arunachal Pradesh, the Apatani community is closely connected to its valley landscape, traditional agriculture and distinctive cultural practices.

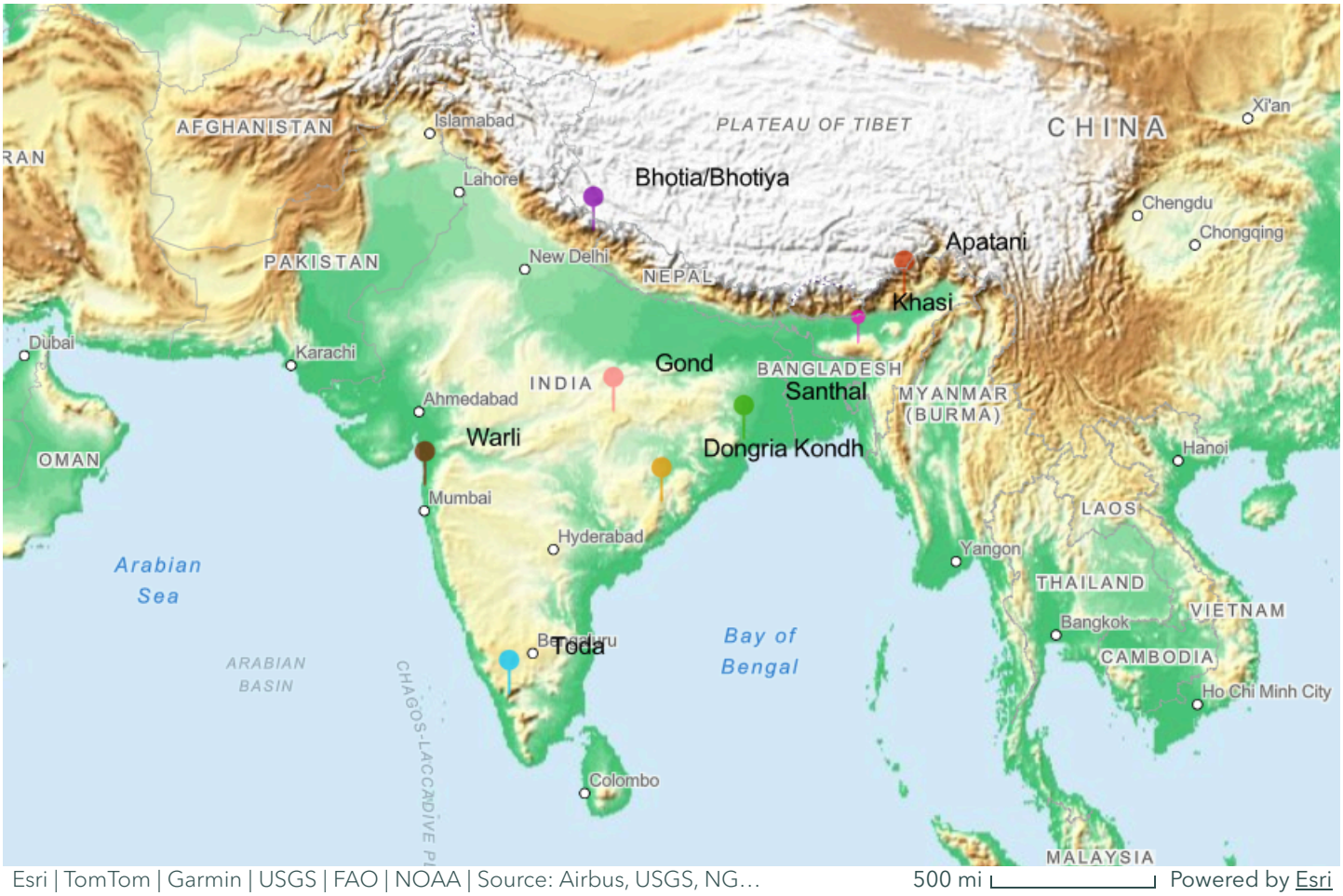




Khasi: Culture in the Hills of Meghalaya

The Khasi communities of Meghalaya have developed a distinctive cultural identity shaped by the region's hilly terrain, forests and long-standing traditions.





People and the Landscapes They Call Home

From the high Himalayas to the plateaus and hills of central and southern India, landscape has played an important role in shaping the livelihoods and cultural practices of tribal communities.





Warli: Art, Land and Community

Where everyday life becomes a visual language



A Culture Told Through Art

Warli painting reflects everyday life, nature and community traditions. Farming, animals, celebrations and village life are expressed through simple geometric forms. The art also carries cultural knowledge from one generation to another.





Life Connected to the Land

Warli communities have traditionally depended on small-scale farming and forest resources. Rice, pulses and vegetables

form part of their cultivation, while nature remains closely connected with everyday life and cultural practices.



The Rhythm of the Tarpa

Music and dance are an important part of Warli community life. The Tarpa, a traditional wind instrument, accompanies group performances connected with celebration, community and nature.

Toda: Life in the Nilgiris

The Toda are an Indigenous pastoral community of the Nilgiri Hills in Tamil Nadu. Their culture is closely connected with buffalo herding, distinctive architecture, traditional dress and the mountain landscape.

Gond: People of Gondwana

The Gond are one of the major Adivasi communities of central India, with historic settlements across the Vindhya and Satpura ranges and the Narmada region. The wider region was historically known as **Gondwana**, reflecting the presence of Gond kingdoms in central India. Their cultural traditions include festivals, songs, dances and oral storytelling.

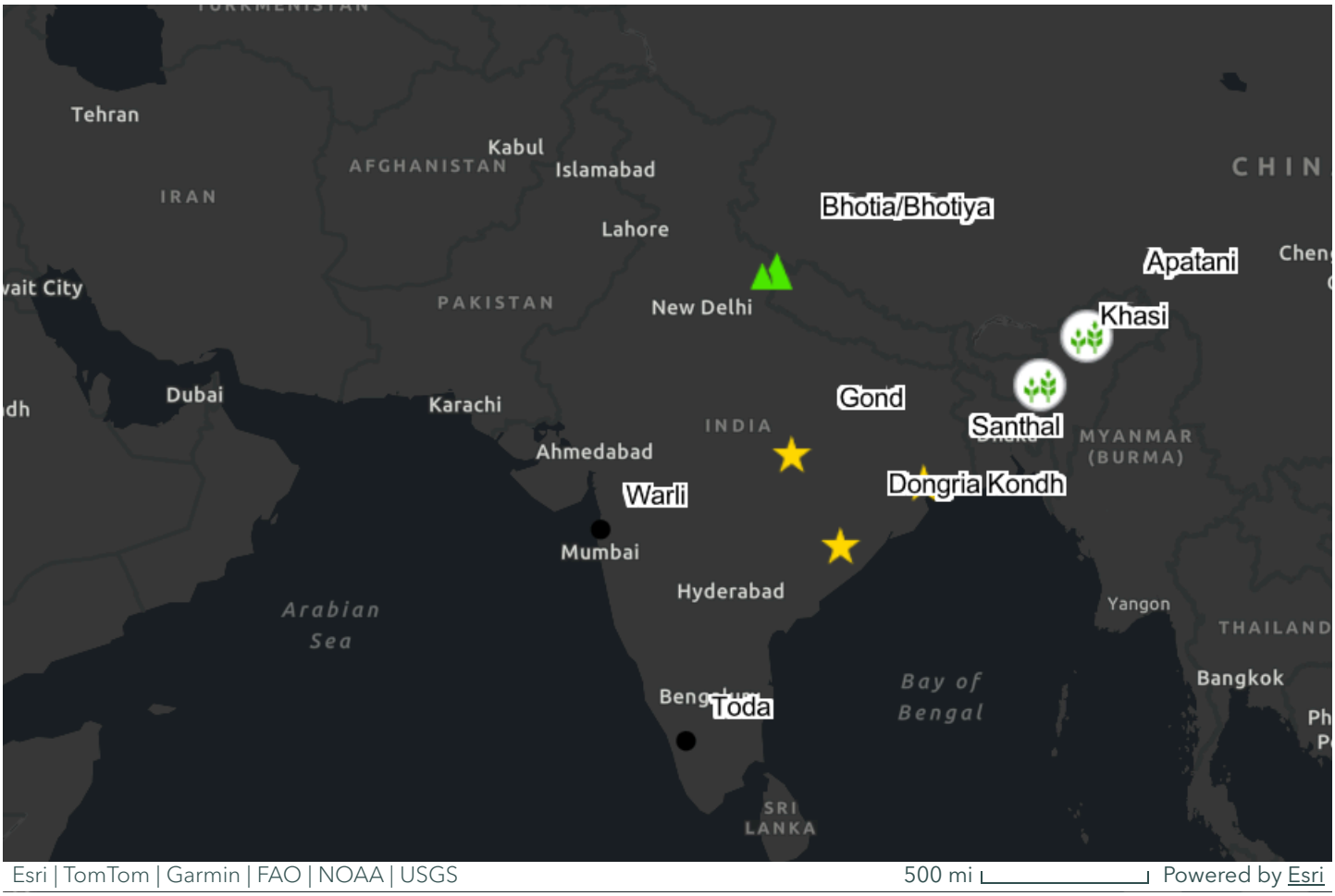
One of their most recognisable cultural expressions is **Gond painting**, where stories, beliefs and scenes involving animals, birds, trees and village life are transformed into colourful visual narratives using distinctive patterns of dots and lines.

Santhal: A Culture of Song and Dance

The Santhal are one of eastern India's major Adivasi communities, with a strong presence across Jharkhand, West Bengal, Odisha and Bihar. Their settlements are closely associated with the Chota Nagpur Plateau and surrounding forested landscapes. Santhal culture has a rich tradition of **music, dance and oral storytelling**, with songs carrying stories of community life, seasonal cycles and social traditions. Their festivals, such as **Sohrai and Baha**, are important occasions for collective celebration.

Dongria Kondh: Life in the Niyamgiri Hills

The Dongria Kondh live mainly in the **Niyamgiri Hills of Odisha**, a mountainous landscape of dense forests and streams. Their settlements and livelihoods are closely associated with the hills, where they practise horticulture and cultivate crops such as millet, pulses and fruits. The community is particularly known for its distinctive **traditional jewellery, colourful clothing and intricate body ornaments**, which are important expressions of identity.



Four Tribal Regions of India

The communities explored in this story are spread across four broad geographical settings — Western & Southern India, Central & Eastern India, Himalayan India and Northeast India. Their locations show how India's cultural diversity is closely distributed across very different landscapes.

A Living Heritage

From the Himalayas to the forests of central India and the hills of the Northeast and Western Ghats, these communities show the diversity of India's living heritage. Their art, festivals, livelihoods and traditions are shaped by the landscapes they call home.

Heritage is not only something preserved from the past — it continues through people, places and everyday life.

Eight communities. Many landscapes. One living heritage.